

Session 5: Sexual Immorality Inside the Church

Key Takeaways

- The Christian sexual ethic is not based solely on individual choice and consent. Rather, it's grounded in the belief that our actions have full-community impact, whether they are done privately or not.
- Paul distinguishes between those who belong to the body of believers and those outside the body.
- Paul does not instruct people to correct the sexual behaviors common in the world or even to pass judgment on them. Instead, he is addressing church members specifically.

Paul's Teaching on Sexual Relationships

This section as a whole deals with how Paul frames sexual relations and sexual immorality, how he views the body and what we do with it, but it isn't only about that. It's also about other behaviors that destroy the body.

His teaching follows two main threads:

1. What Paul wants to impress upon them about their bodies in relation to Jesus Christ and to one another. This forms the foundation of his sexual ethic in these chapters.
2. The distinction he makes between the body of believers and those outside the body. He is very strict at judging the former and not the latter.

What this section very specifically does not address is any sense of the Church needing to correct the world or even to pass judgment on the world in relation to sexual ethics. This is all about internal church relations, and it is a window into how Paul dealt with sexual disorder, marriage, singleness, and virginity.

Summary Verses: 1 Corinthians 6:19-20

1 Corinthians 6:19-20 NRSV

¹⁹ Or do you not know that your body is a temple of the Holy Spirit within you, which you have from God, and that you are not your own? ²⁰ For you were bought with a price; therefore glorify God in your body.

Immorality at Corinth

1 Corinthians 5 begins with Paul addressing a report about sexual immorality (Greek: *porneia*/πορνεία—fornication, from which we get the term pornography). He has heard that a man in the church is having sex with his father's wife.

Although this is not his birth mother, it's his stepmother, this relationship is classed as incest in Roman law, hence Paul's comment that not even pagans tolerate this behavior. It was punishable by law.

We don't know the exact circumstances. What might it mean that they are proud about it? Was he powerful or rich? Was he a patron or a leader?

Paul's views here are very strong! "To deliver such a one to Satan for the destruction of the flesh." What might Paul mean by that?

Those in the "World" and Those in the Body

1 Corinthians 5:9-13 NRSV

⁹ I wrote to you in my letter not to associate with sexually immoral persons— ¹⁰ not at all meaning the immoral of this world, or the greedy and robbers, or idolaters, since you would then need to go out of the world. ¹¹ But now I am writing to you not to associate with anyone who bears the name of brother or sister who is sexually immoral or greedy, or is an idolater, reviler, drunkard, or robber. Do not even eat with such a one. ¹² For what have I to do with judging those outside? Is it not those who are inside that you are to judge? ¹³ God will judge those outside. "Drive out the wicked person from among you."

Note the behaviors Paul identifies.

The people in the world that we have to associate with in our everyday lives include:

- τοῖς πλεονέκταις (Greek: *tois pleonektais*—the covetous, you want more of what others have)
- ἄρπαξ (Greek: *harpax*—swindler, robber, extortioner)
- εἰδωλόλατραις (Greek: *idololatrais*—idolaters)

The people in the body who Paul thinks we shouldn't mix with (not even eat with!) are all those above plus:

- λοῖδορος (Greek: *loidoros*—verbal abuser)
- μέθυσος (Greek: *methusos*—drunkard)

Reflection Question

What is the significance of Paul addressing followers of Jesus and not the "world" (i.e., those who do not claim to follow Jesus)? How does this inform the way followers of Jesus can understand sexual ethics today?